PRD: A new audience control option in the LinkedIn post composer

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Summary

We are adding a third audience option to the LinkedIn post composer, **Anyone, except…**, so a job seeker can keep a post public while hiding it from chosen groups or people. It is for job seekers searching where they have no established professional network yet, who hold back real posts because they fear judgment from people who know them, or fear a post will look calculated to one specific person, like a recruiter they are talking to. Today they can only pick Anyone or Connections only, and both include the people they fear. **The fewer they post, the fewer their chances to be discovered**, which is the outcome both their job search and LinkedIn depend on.

WHY NOW

For job seekers abroad, LinkedIn is close to required. Most applications ask for a profile link (4 of 8 survey responses), and it is where they build a professional network from scratch, so staying quiet there keeps them invisible to the people who could help. LinkedIn already controls who sees a post through Connections only, so this builds on an existing control rather than needing a new system. It helps a segment that holds back to post more, which is value for them and for LinkedIn's engagement.

Problem and evidence

Job seekers abroad without an established local network only post when something real has happened, and even then they often hold back. One reason the product controls: **they cannot keep a post away from the people whose judgment they fear.**

Evidence	Source
Post only when something real happens, and refuse to fake it	4 of 5 interviewees; among the three most picked survey reasons (4 of 8 each)
Posted twice or less in the past 3 months	5 of 8 survey responses
Withdrew a post because of who would see it: one feared her home network, the other one recruiter	2 of 5 interviewees; the home-network fear scored the highest intensity (5 of 5) in Phase 2
A LinkedIn link is required for most or all applications	4 of 8 survey responses

EVIDENCE GAP

The audience-fear evidence is real but thin: two interviewees, and it should have been surveyed but was not. That is why this PRD treats it as an assumption to test, not a proven fact.

User and context

Emma (the Phase 2 persona) is job hunting abroad; the prototype uses Berlin as an example city. Back home she never had to look for a job, and no one there has seen her struggle. She has a small network in Berlin and is trying to widen it.

Where it breaks: she has something real to share, a lesson from her job search. She drafts it, then reaches one of the doubts from her Phase 2 journey, the one this PRD addresses: her former colleagues in India will see she has been struggling for 7 months. The doubt wins and she deletes the post. She stays invisible to the people in her field in Berlin who could have found her.

Who is in the segment: job seekers searching where they have no established professional network: relocated and hunting in the new country, relocating again to another country, or applying abroad while still living at home.

Goals and non-goals

OVERALL GOAL (FROM PHASE 2)

Improve job seekers' profile discovery twice as often (search appearances / profile views) within 3 months, without lowering post engagement.

THIS FEATURE'S GOAL

Job seekers in the segment post 20% more per month, because the posts they used to hold back now go out. One feature will not double discovery alone; it moves the lever that drives it.

Non-goals (decided not to build):

- **Saved or custom audience lists.** No list manager, naming or editing. Groups come from her profile; people are picked per post.
- **Showing a post only to chosen people.** It removes strangers, which defeats discovery.
- **Anonymous posting.** Nobody can find her profile from an anonymous post.
- **Hiding her comments, profile or Open to Work status.** This covers posts only.
- **Blocking screenshots or word of mouth.** Not controllable by the product.
- **Fixing the other posting causes** (drafting outside LinkedIn, unclear what is worth posting). Covered by other ideas in the Steps document.

Solution

One new option in the existing audience picker, using data LinkedIn already has: her work history and her connections.

1. Emma taps **Start a post** and writes her update. The audience chip shows **Anyone**, as today.
2. She taps the chip. The sheet shows **Anyone**, **Connections only** and the new **Anyone, except...**
3. Choosing **Anyone, except...** reveals two ways to hide:
   a. **Your connections from [company]:** one checkbox per company on her profile, with a count. It includes only her connections who worked there, wherever they work now.
   b. **Specific people:** search her connections and pick anyone, such as a recruiter or a relative.
4. A summary line updates live: "Visible to everyone except 143 people." She taps **Done**.
5. Back in the composer, the chip names what is hidden, for example "Anyone except 2 companies +1 (143)", with the line "They won't see this in their feed, search, or on your activity." She taps **Post**.
6. She lands on her feed with her post at the top and a confirmation of who it was hidden from.
7. The next day, post insights show reach beyond her network, top viewer locations, and a **Hidden from** card confirming who it was hidden from. One button lets her **post her next update with the same audience**.

If her profile shows a current employer, that company appears in step 3 as its own checkbox, labelled (current).

Rollout: tested with job seekers abroad first; if posting rises and the guardrails hold, it rolls out to all members.

Alternatives considered: two other ideas tied with this one on RICE (6 each); this is the only one of them that removes a cause rather than softening it. Within audience control, showing a post only to chosen people shrinks reach, anonymous posting kills discovery, posting in a group limits reach, and hiding by location is too broad. Full scoring is in the Steps document.

LIVE PROTOTYPE

pixel-perfect-showcase-7419.lovable.app

WALKTHROUGH VIDEO

Watch the walkthrough on Loom

Requirements

User stories and acceptance criteria

1. Hide by company

As a job seeker, I want to keep my post public but hide it from people I worked with, so new people can find me without my former colleagues judging me.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- **Anyone, except...** appears as a third option, below Anyone and Connections only.
- Selecting it lists every company on her profile as a checkbox with a count.
- A count includes only her connections whose time at that company overlapped with hers.
- Ticking a company updates the summary line and the composer chip immediately.

2. Hide specific people

As a job seeker, I want to hide a post from chosen people, so I can cover cases a company group gets wrong, like one recruiter, or a company where some colleagues are friends.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- She can search her connections and tick any of them.
- Picked people appear as removable chips; removing the last one unticks Specific people.
- Someone in a ticked company and also picked by name is counted once.

3. Hidden means hidden everywhere

As a job seeker, I want to trust that hidden people cannot see my post, so I feel safe posting.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Hidden people never see the post in feed, search, her activity, notifications, reposts, private sends or email digests.
- A hidden person opening a direct link sees "This post isn't available", the same message as a deleted post.
- Hidden people are never notified that they were hidden.

4. See it worked, and post again

As a job seeker, I want to see that my post reached new people and none of the hidden ones, so I feel confident to post again.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Post insights show the share of viewers outside her network and top viewer locations.
- A **Hidden from** card lists each hidden company or person with a check mark, confirming the post was hidden from them.
- **Post your next update with this same audience** opens the composer with that audience already set.

Edge cases

Situation	Behaviour
A mutual connection reposts her post	The repost is hidden from the same people
She tags or mentions a hidden person	Blocked, with a note: "You've hidden this post from [name]"
A signed-out visitor or search engine	Shown to signed-in members only, so hidden people cannot see it while logged out
A company with no connections from her time there	Not listed
She is currently employed	Her current company is listed and labelled (current)

Empty states

Screen	What it shows
Anyone, except... with nothing ticked	Done disabled; "Select a group or person to hide from."
No work history on her profile	"Add your experience to hide people by company." Specific people still works
People search with no match	"No connections match '[name]'."
Insights before anyone has viewed	"Your post is just getting started. Check back tomorrow."

Success metrics

Associated goal: improve job seekers' profile discovery twice as often within 3 months. Measured with an A/B test inside the segment, checked monthly: Group A gets the feature, Group B does not, assigned at random so the only systematic difference is the feature. **Who is in the test:** job seekers abroad without a local network, found using signals LinkedIn already has: Open to Work is switched on, and either their profile location changed recently or they are looking for jobs in another country. Full reasoning is in the Steps document.

Type	Metric	What success looks like	Why
Key	**Posts per job seeker per month**	**Group A posts 20% more than Group B**	Measures the behaviour the feature should change
Secondary	Profile views from non-connections; new connections	Group A higher than Group B	Shows posting turns into discovery, the goal
Secondary	Adoption, repeat use, posts from the "same audience" button (Group A only)	Tracked to diagnose; no target	Separates "doesn't work" from "not found"
Guardrail	Engagement rate per post, each post's first 7 days	Group A at least 90% of Group B	More posts must not mean worse posts that lose reach
Guardrail	"Not interested" or hide rate	Group A not above Group B	Catches low-quality posts directly

Baseline: Group B over the same period. **Deadline:** end of month 3, checked monthly. Discovery targets are set after month 1, once the share of non-connection profile views that come from posts is known; a number before that would be a guess. If a guardrail is breached, Group A's posts are split by audience type to see where the change comes from.

Events to log: audience option chosen, companies and people hidden per post, post published with its audience type, hidden person shown "This post isn't available", insights viewed, "same audience" button tapped.

Long-term outcomes (referrals, mentorship, interview leads) take longer than 3 months and are not measured directly here.

Risks and open questions

Risk	How we would spot it	What reduces it
Control removes the fear but posting does not increase	High adoption, flat key metric	The A/B test is designed to catch this
Posting more does not lead to discovery	Key metric rises, profile views from non-connections stay flat	Secondary metrics catch it early; rethink what drives discovery
Screenshots or word of mouth reach hidden people	User reports	Not preventable; reposts, private sends and email digests are blocked for hidden people
Hidden people feel excluded if they find out, and Emma fears being found out	Low repeat use of the feature	Exclusion stays invisible: no notifications, generic "not available" message
Less content from people they know in hidden users' feeds	Feed engagement among hidden users	Small during the test, since the segment is small; re-check before rolling out to everyone

Open question	Who decides
Is audience fear common enough to justify the build? It rests on 2 of 5 interviewees and was not surveyed	PM, with a short survey before build
Is a company group fixed when she posts, or checked each time someone views (for example, a former colleague who connects with her next month)?	PM and engineering
Can she change the audience after posting?	Design
Should she be able to untick individual friends inside a company group? Possible later version	PM, after adoption data
Do quiet stranger audiences make the feed ranking show her posts less?	Feed ranking team

Dependencies: the visibility rules that already enforce Connections only (feed, search, reposts, email digests); the feed ranking team; analytics for event logging; a privacy review of hiding by company.